

came up with additional proposals. The IIA included these in *The Laws of War on Land*, a manual that was approved at a conference in Oxford in 1880. Although it believed that an international treaty was unrealistic at the time, it appealed to governments to adopt the codes as national law. The Lieber Code and *The Laws of War on Land* laid the groundwork for the creation of a truly international codification of the rules of war.

Multilateral agreement

As the arms race accelerated, particularly between Britain and Germany toward the end of the 19th century, so peace movements gained wider support. In 1891, the International Peace Bureau was formed. Based in Berne, Switzerland, it campaigned for world peace and promoted arbitration and disarmament. The development of modern, more deadly weaponry had changed the nature of conflict, and peace campaigners and even some

Delegates at the first Hague Peace Conference included representatives from China, France, Germany, the Russian Federation, Great Britain, Spain, and the United States.

heads of state believed that limits should be placed on the most destructive weapons.

It was against this backdrop that the first Hague Conference was proposed by Czar Nicholas II of Russia. Convened in The Hague in 1899, it was attended by delegates from 26 nations. The main aims of the conference were to control the arms race and negotiate disarmament, codify the rules of war, and find a way to peacefully resolve international disputes without resorting to war.

Although it failed to adopt a program for disarmament, the conference ratified three treaties and some additional declarations—together, these formed the first of the Hague Conventions. They included important rules on the conduct of war, forbidding the execution of surrendered enemy combatants; the use of projectiles containing poison gas; the launch of explosives from balloons; the use of bullets that expand in the body (dumdums); and attacks on undefended towns or villages.

The conference also agreed to create the Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague. This was the first international institution to provide legal solutions for disputes

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Waging war we understand,
but not waging peace,
or at any rate less
consciously so.

Fredrik Bajer

**Honorary president of the
International Bureau of Peace
(1837–1922)**

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between states. More than 50 nations ratified the first Hague Convention and, alongside the Geneva Conventions, it served as the foundation of international humanitarian law.

A further conference was called by US president Theodore Roosevelt in 1904, but it had to be delayed due to the war between Russia and Japan. It was finally convened in 1907, when 43 states met. No major changes were made to the provisions of the 1899 Convention, but they were improved to incorporate warfare at sea, for

